line. I didn't go into the tackle with any intention other than winning the ball, so when the ref said I was off I was shocked more than anything else. I've seen it on video since and I must admit that, on television, it looked a bad challenge. I didn't think it was, though, and I was relieved that the manager didn't either. He was really angry after the game: not with me but with the match officials. I think the way their player reacted had a lot to do with why I was sent off. I probably should have been more aware that we were in South America and that, perhaps, things weren't quite the same over there. I was absolutely crushed by it that evening, although I have to admit that, within a few days, lounging by the pool while the rest of the lads were confined to their hotel rooms before the game against Vasco da Gama, I didn't feel quite so disappointed about how things had worked out.

Being in Brazil was fantastic. I remember one evening wandering down to Copacabana Beach on my own. You hear about it but it's beyond anything you'd ever imagine. The beach just stretched away for what seemed like miles. There were goalposts and little sets of floodlights planted along the whole length of it. And, as far as the eye could see, kids—thousands of them—out playing soccer on the sand. No wonder Brazil are world champions. All these youngsters were either playing games or doing tricks or showing off flicks and turns in twos and threes. The level of natural ability was unbelievable. A couple of them recognized me and asked me to take some free-kicks while their mates went in goal. If soccer's got a soul, that's where it lives: on that beach. I'll never forget my evening out there with those kids.

Brazil in January was hot. Great weather for a vacation or a walk by the sea at night. But for playing competitive soccer? I think it was a lesson for all of us. People laugh about the English going abroad, what we're like in the sun. When it came to United in Rio at the World Club Championship, the jokes weren't far wrong. The first time we arrived at the Maracana stadium, we were already sweating from the walk from the coach to the front door. We walked into the dressing room and I remember some of the lads were actually in the middle of a conversation about how hot it was. Next thing, everybody's gone quiet. Standing there in the middle of the room were seven beds with oxygen masks hanging down. I don't think any of us knew what to say. *What were we in for here?*

When we went out to warm up—is that the right phrase, at one o'clock in the afternoon and in temperatures of over 100 degrees—the Mexicans were jogging around in light undershirts. We ran out wearing our regular black training tops, all trying to head for the tiny patches of shade by the touchlines under the stands. None of us will ever forget those thirteen days in Brazil.